KASHI'S NEW CACHET

Varanasi is now a regular pit stop for shoots and film promotions. What explains the film world's obsession with the holy city?

By Suhani Singh



> WHEN IN BANARAS (Clockwise from R) Director S.S. Rajamouli with stars NTR Jr and Ram Charan for the *RRR* promo; Kartik Aaryan at one of the ghats; Ranbir, Alia and director Ayan Mukerji shoot for *Brahmastra*

WHEN KARTIK AARYAN WANTED TO celebrate the fantastic opening of his latest release, *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2*, he didn't think of lazing by the beach in Bollywood's favourite holiday destination, the Maldives. The actor, instead, chose Varanasi, where he took a boat ride on the Ganga and prayed at one of the many ghats on its banks.

But then he's hardly the first film celebrity to be smitten by the holy city. In the past few months, filmmaker S.S. Rajamouli, and Ram Charan and NTR Jr, the leading men of his period action spectacle, *RRR*, held a press conference by the Ganga; Akshay Kumar and his *Samrat Prithviraj* co-star, former Miss World winner Manushi Chillar, visited the Kashi Vishwanath temple for film promotions; and so did Kangana Ranaut who released a track from *Dhaakad*. The song played on a floating LED screen on the banks of the river.

Unfortunately, Kumar and Ranaut's prayers went unheard as both films sank without a trace. Ranbir Kapoor and Alia Bhatt, who shot a segment of their upcoming film, *Brahmastra*, and the song 'Kesariya' in the city, will hope for a better fate. But such is the entertainment influx in the temple town that it begs the question: why is Bollywood suddenly besotted with Banaras?

"Varanasi has a hold over the collec-

